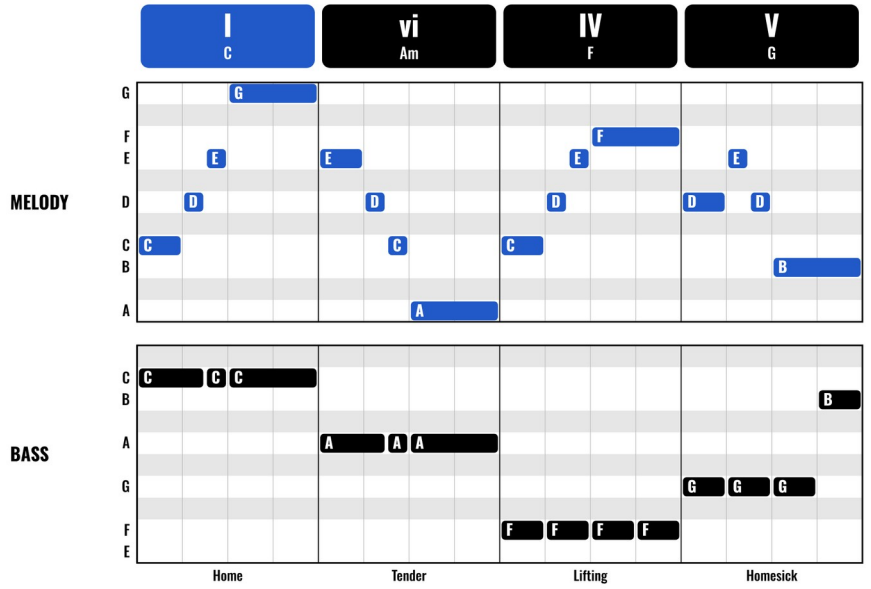
HUDSON BEAT



BASS & MELODY WRITING

Feat. Seven Nation Army

DIGITAL MUSIC PRODUCTION · UNIT 4 · DAY 1 · BASSLINES AND MELODIES IN LOGIC PRO

WHAT THE HECK IS A MELODY?

- The tune you hum after the song ends
- One note at a time, on top of the chords
- Short, repetitive and singable
- Simple and repetitive wins

LISTEN: A MELODY A STADIUM CAN SING

SEVEN NATION ARMY

The White Stripes

Teacher: play the first 30 seconds from YouTube or Spotify.

- How many different notes do you hear?
- How many times does it repeat?
- Could you hum it after one listen?

BRIGHT OR DARK?

C MAJOR SCALE › A NATURAL MINOR SCALE

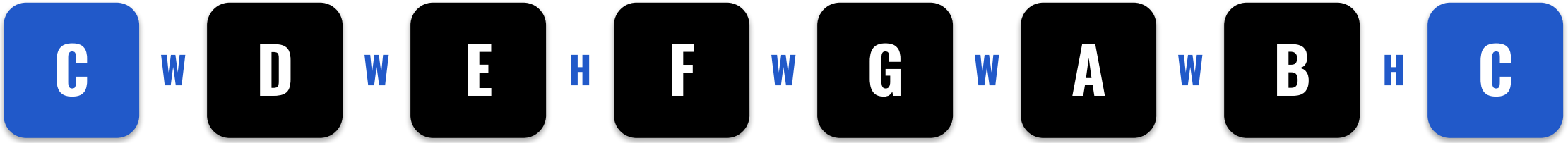
teacher plays on a piano sound

Same seven white keys, two starting notes.

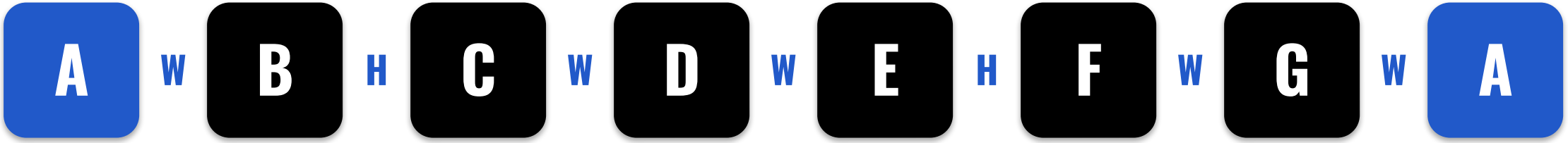
- Which one sounds brighter?
- Which one sounds darker?
- What changed?

A SCALE IS YOUR INGREDIENT LIST

C MAJOR · W - W - H - W - W - W - H



A NATURAL MINOR · W - H - W - W - H - W - W



Every white key is a safe note. Start or end on the root: C or A.

FOUR DAYS, TWO SHORT PROJECTS

DAY 1

SCALES + MELODY START · MELODY

A melody is short, repetitive and singable; scales; four ways to write it; start your melody

DAY 2

FINISH THE MELODY, MEET THE BASS RULE · MELODY + THE BASS RULE

Finish the melody; frequency separation; look hard at a bassline and find the rule

DAY 3

PLAN + BUILD THE BASSLINE · BASSLINE

Plan four chords with Roman numerals; roots first, then rhythm; build the bassline

DAY 4

PRESENTATIONS · PRESENT

Play it, explain it: what key, what Roman numerals, what did you want it to feel like?

FOUR WAYS TO WRITE A MELODY

1 · Play it in

Good when you can already hear an idea in your head.

2 · Draw a rhythm first

Good when you have a groove but no tune yet.

3 · Click one note, move it

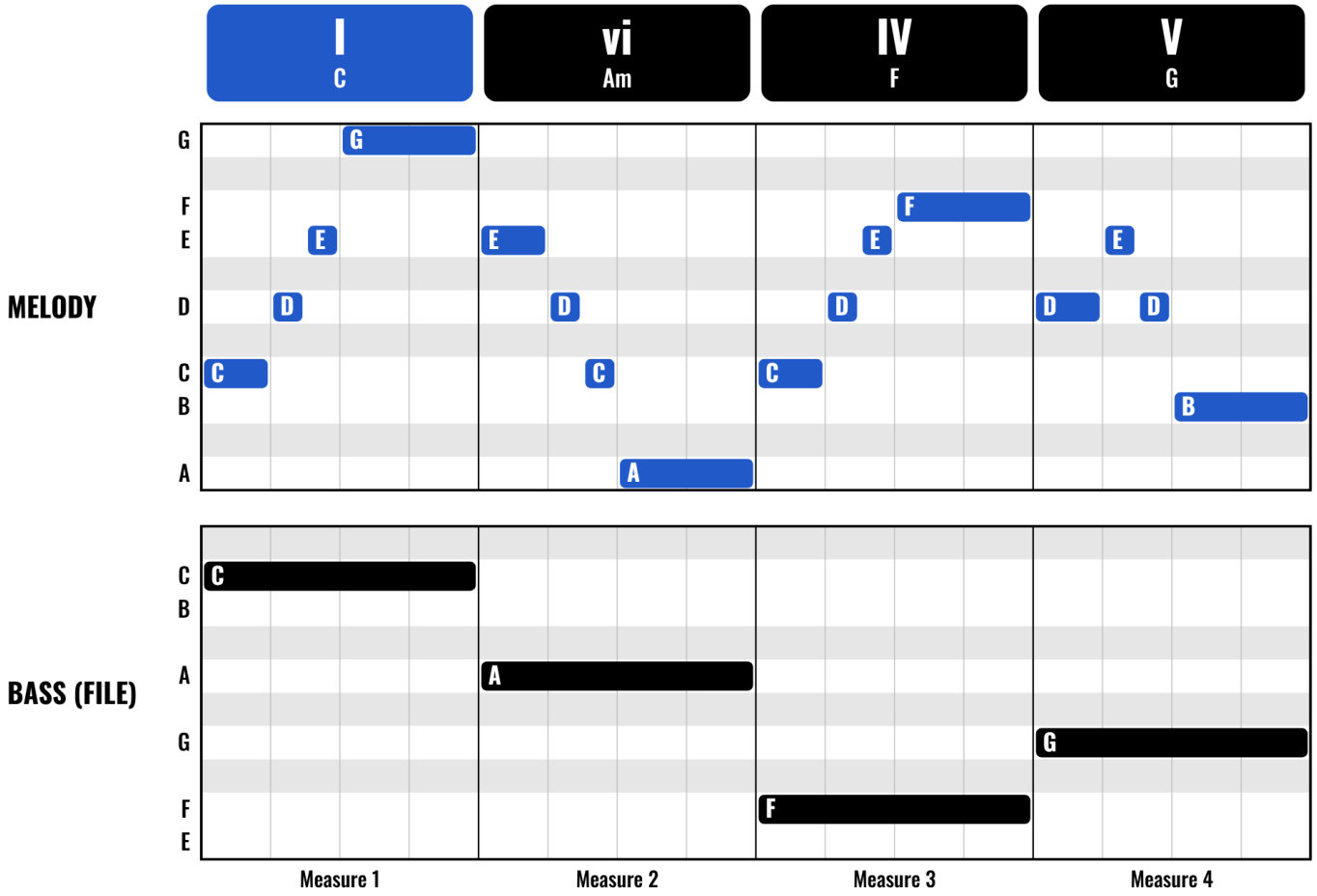
Good when you want to build slowly, one decision at a time.

4 · Use the step sequencer

Good when you want a short, repeating, rhythmic hook.

Whichever way: 2 or 4 measures, notes from your scale, start or end on the root.

WORKED EXAMPLE: A MELODY OVER THE CHORDS



- Blue: your melody, one note at a time
- Black: the bassline already in the file
- Each measure starts on a note of its chord
- Same rhythm every measure: easy to remember

WATCH ME: RECORD, QUANTIZE, COPY

1. Open the chords-and-bass file; save it as Part 2
2. Shift the keyboard up an octave (OCT +)
3. New track, a lead or synth sound
4. Loop 2 measures, press R, play; then Q
5. Copy and paste it across the progression

HOW TO WRITE A MELODY

- Keep it short: 2 or 4 measures
- White keys only: no wrong notes
- Give it shape: up, then down
- Start or end on the root
- Simple and repetitive wins

MELODY: WHAT YOU TURN IN

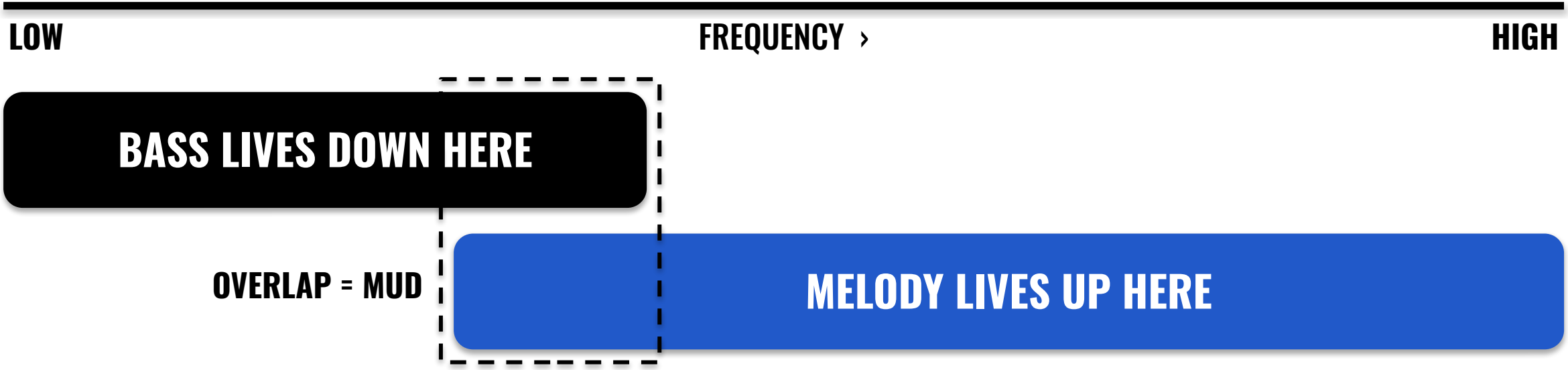
- [ ] Scale pages of the packet done
- [ ] 2 or 4 measures, in your scale
- [ ] Starts or ends on the root
- [ ] Played in and quantized, or clicked in
- [ ] Own track, a different sound from the bass
- [ ] MP3 + .zip, named Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2

MELODY: HOW IT'S SCORED

MELODY WRITING	5 = In key, short, starts or ends on the root, clear contour.	/ 5
TECHNICAL SKILL	5 = Confident piano roll; well placed, well timed; both entry methods.	/ 5
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	5 = Named correctly, on time; explains the melody choices clearly.	/ 5

SCORED 2 TO 5 · TOTAL / 15

MIXING MOMENT: FREQUENCY SEPARATION



- Melody: Channel EQ, turn on the low cut (high-pass)
- Bass: roll off the extreme highs (high cut)
- Every instrument gets a frequency home

LISTEN: FOLLOW THE BASS

STAND BY ME

Ben E. King

Teacher: play the first minute from YouTube or Spotify.

- Hum the bass, not the singer.
- Where does the bass pattern start again?
- What happens to it when the chords change?

THE ONE RULE FOR BASSLINES

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

Everything else is rhythm and decoration on top of this rule.

I · C
bass plays C

vi · Am
bass plays A

IV · F
bass plays F

V · G
bass plays G

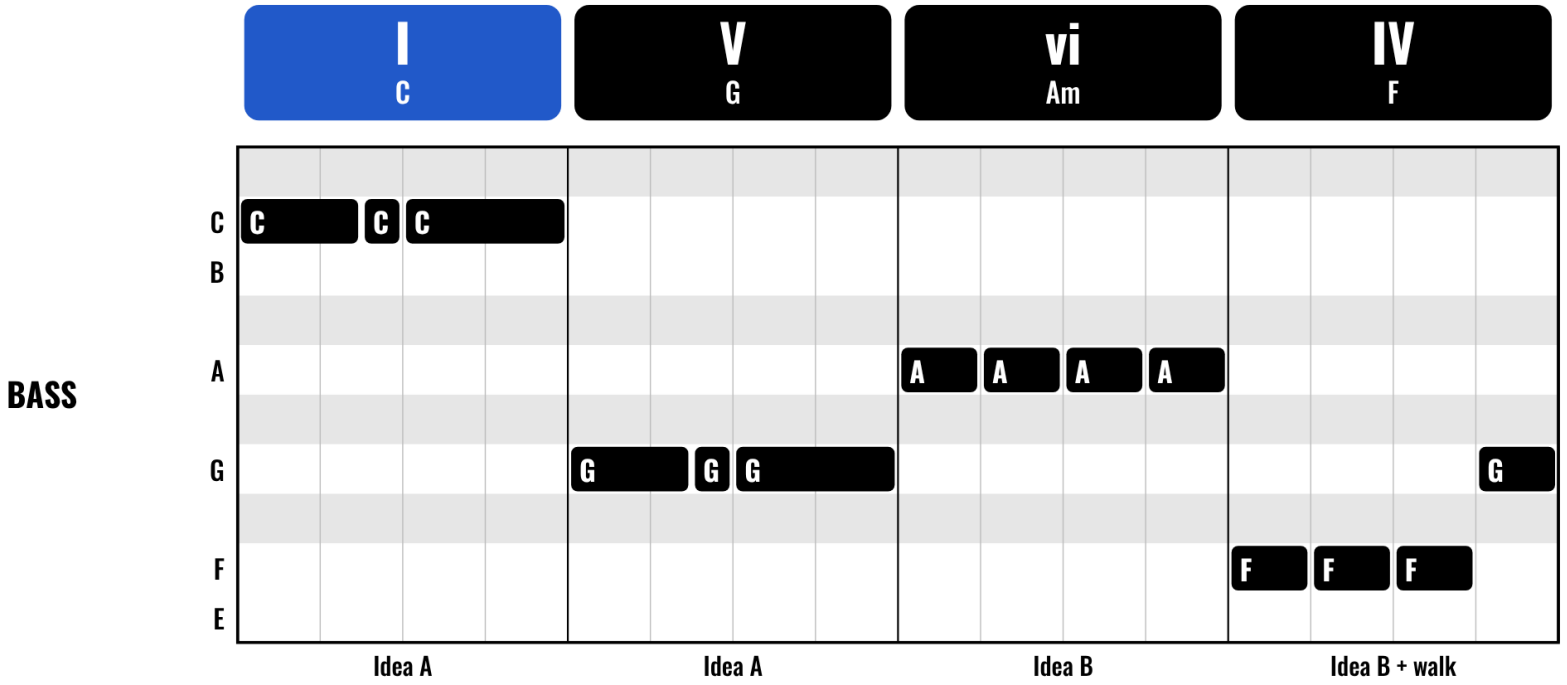
PLAN YOUR PROGRESSION

CHORD 1	CHORD 2	CHORD 3	CHORD 4
Roman numeral	Roman numeral	Roman numeral	Roman numeral
I	**V**	**vi**	**IV**
Root note	Root note	Root note	Root note
C	**G**	**A**	**F**

Why did you choose this progression? What did you want it to feel like?

Example: “I start at home, the V pulls away, the vi turns tender, and the IV lifts it so the loop wants to start again.”

WORKED EXAMPLE: A BASSLINE



- Root on beat 1 of every chord
- Two rhythm ideas: A and B
- One note at a time: no overlaps
- The last note leans into the next chord

The plan: I – V – vi – IV in C major = C, G, Am, F

WATCH ME: ROOTS FIRST, THEN RHYTHM

1. New file: build your four chords from the card
2. Bass track: one whole-note root per chord
3. Play the bass alone, then with the chords
4. Add rhythm: at least two ideas
5. Zoom in: no overlapping notes

BASSLINE: WHAT YOU TURN IN

- [ ] Part 4 analysis in the packet done
- [ ] Planning table: Roman numerals + roots
- [ ] Monophonic: no overlapping notes
- [ ] Root at every chord change
- [ ] At least 2 rhythmic ideas + your why
- [ ] MP3 + .zip, named Your Name — Building Blocks Part 4

BASSLINE: HOW IT'S SCORED

BASSLINE CONSTRUCTION	5 = Monophonic, follows every chord change, clear rhythmic identity.	/ 5
HARMONIC INTENTION	5 = Clear emotional character, explained in Roman numeral language.	/ 5
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	5 = Named correctly, on time; presents chord choices with Roman numerals.	/ 5

SCORED 2 TO 5 · TOTAL / 15

DAY 4

PRESENTATION DAY

- Play your melody, then your bassline
- What key? What Roman numerals?
- What did you want it to feel like?
- Respond to at least 2 classmates

ONE LAST THING...

- You wrote a melody.
- You built chords.
- You wrote a bassline.
- The foundation of every song.

